

SUMMER TRIP · 10 DAYS

GREECE

July 1 – 10, 2026

Athens • Thessaloniki • Sithonia

A northern loop: capital → food city → the best beaches
you can reach without backtracking.

Athens • Thessaloniki • Sithonia (Halkidiki) A north-loop trip: capital → food city → the best beaches you can reach without backtracking.

At a glance

Dates	Base	Nights	The point of it
Jul 2–4	Athens	2	Acropolis, ancient core, rooftop sunsets
Jul 4–6	Thessaloniki	2	Greece's food capital, Byzantine + Ottoman old town
Jul 6–10	Sithonia, Halkidiki	4	Pine-backed coves, a private-boat lagoon day
Jul 10	Fly home from SKG	—	Drive ~2 hr from Sithonia to the airport

Why Sithonia for the beach leg (you left it open between Halkidiki / Corfu / Kefalonia): it's the only one reachable from Thessaloniki **without a connecting flight** — a 1.5–2.5 hr drive, no transit day burned. Corfu and Kefalonia have **no direct flights from SKG** (you'd connect via Athens each way). Starting and ending in the north, the northern beach is the clean choice. (Want the classic Ionian island instead? See the last page — but reverse the trip order.)

Book-now checklist (July is peak — these sell out)

Priority	What	When	Rough cost
1	Acropolis timed-entry ticket	Now	€20 (combo €30)
2	Sithonia accommodation (4 nts)	Now	see lodging
3	Rental car , pick up SKG/Thess Jul 6, drop SKG Jul 10	Now	~€200–260
4	ATH → SKG flight , Jul 4 AM	2–3 mo out	€50–90
5	City hotels (Athens ×2, Thessaloniki ×2)	2–3 mo out	see lodging
6	Weekend dinner reservations (Thessaloniki books up)	1 wk out	—
7	eSIM (Airalo/Holafly Greece)	Before you fly	€5–15

ATHENS · July 2-4

Where to stay

Tier	Hotel	Why
Comfort	AthensWas (Koukaki)	Across from the Acropolis Museum; rooftop arguably the best Acropolis view of any hotel. From ~€160.
Classic 5★	Electra Palace (Plaka)	Rooftop pool + direct Acropolis views from the best suites. From ~€180.
Best value	Herodion (Makrigianni)	Steps from the museum, reliable, great location. From ~€130.

Stay in Plaka, Koukaki, or Makrigianni — all walkable to the Acropolis.

Where to eat

- **Psarras** (Plaka, since 1898) — terraced, grilled octopus & sea bream. The atmospheric classic.
- **Scholarchio** (Plaka) — local favorite off the tourist drag; tray of mezedes to point at.
- **Saita** (Plaka) — quiet end of Kydathineon; famous bakaliaros skordalia (salt cod + garlic).
- **Avli** (Psyri) — courtyard taverna that fills 10 min after opening. Get there early.

Day plan

Jul 2 — Arrive & the rock - Land AM, drop bags, light lunch in Plaka. - ~17:00 **Acropolis** (late = softer light, fewer crowds). Down through the **Acropolis Slopes** → **Ancient Agora**. - Sunset rooftop drink in Monastiraki → dinner at **Psarras** or **Avli**.

Jul 3 — Museum + neighborhoods - 09:00 **Acropolis Museum** (do it after the rock — it lands better). - **Monastiraki** flea market → **Anafiotika** (the tiny Cycladic village under the Acropolis). - Late afternoon: **Lycabettus Hill** (funicular) for the full-city panorama. - Dinner in **Psyri** or **Koukaki**. - Beach swap: trade a half-day for the **Athens Riviera** (Vouliagmeni, 35 min taxi).

Jul 4 — Fly north - Morning **ATH** → **SKG**. In Thessaloniki by lunch.

THESSALONIKI · July 4-6

Relaxed, food-obsessed, walkable. UNESCO City of Gastronomy. Stay near **Ladadika** or the **Nea Paralia** waterfront.

Where to eat (this is the reason to come)

- **Full tou Meze** (Ladadika) — the reliable all-rounder; traditional, fair prices, lively.
- **Charoupi** (Ladadika) — refined **Cretan** cooking from an archaeologist-turned-chef.
- **Mezen Salonica** — never-ending small plates: fried red mullet, octopus, tsipouro.
- **Sebrico** (Valaoritou) — creative Greek-meets-global small plates.
- **Bougatsa** for breakfast at **Bantis** or **Giannis** — custard pastry, the local ritual.

Day plan

Jul 4 — Waterfront evening - Check in. Stroll **Nea Paralia** promenade to the **White Tower** at sunset. - Dinner crawl in **Ladadika** (start at Full tou Meze).

Jul 5 — History → market → sunset - AM: **Rotunda**, **Arch of Galerius (Kamara)**, **Agios Dimitrios** church. - Midday: graze **Modiano** + **Kapani** markets; grab a bougatsa. - PM: up to **Ano Poli (Upper Town)** — Ottoman lanes, **Byzantine walls**, **Trigonion Tower** for the best sunset over the bay. - Night: cocktails in **Valaoritou**, the buzziest bar quarter.

Jul 6 — Pick up car, drive south - Collect rental. Drive to Sithonia (~2-2.5 hr). Lunch in **Nikiti**, the gateway town.

SITHONIA, HALKIDIKI · July 6-10

The middle of Halkidiki's three "fingers" — pine forest meeting turquoise water, far less built-up than Kassandra. **Base in Vourvourou or Nikiti**. A car is essential here (bus service is sparse).

Where to stay

Tier	Hotel	Why
Special	Ekies All Senses Resort (Vourvourou)	Beachfront on Vourvourou bay, private beach, sunset beach bar — the one to splurge on.
Luxe-beach	Ergon Beach House (Nikiti)	Chic beach club, locally-sourced dining, turquoise water.
Suites + pool	Lagomandra Luxury Suites (Nikiti)	Private pools, 2 min from Lagomandra Beach.

Day plan

Jul 6 — Settle in (west coast) - Check in, ease into beach mode at **Trani Ammouda (Livrohio)** near Nikiti — long, shallow, calm, beach bars. West-coast sunset.

Jul 7 — The iconic ones - Karidi Beach (Vourvourou) — the postcard: pines, white crescent, water clear enough to see the sand 100 m out. - Afternoon at **Vourvourou** cove + beach bars.

Jul 8 — Diaporos boat day (the highlight) - Rent a small **motorboat** — **no license needed** — from Vourvourou and explore the **Diaporos** mini-archipelago. Anchor in the **Blue Lagoon / Myrsini** ("the Hawaii of Greece"). Pack a picnic + snorkel gear. This is the day you'll remember.

Jul 9 — Wild east coast - Drive east to **Kavourotripes ("Orange Beach")** near Sarti — sculpted white-rock coves with **Mount Athos** rising across the water. Lunch in **Sarti**. Final sunset back west. Pack tonight.

Jul 10 — Fly home - Early start: Sithonia → SKG (~2 hr). Leave **4 hr** before an international departure (July traffic + airport).

What it costs (per person, double occupancy, excl. international airfare)

	Budget	Mid-range	Comfort
Lodging (9 nts, ÷2)	€450	€630	€1,000+
Food & drink (10 days)	€300	€450	€700
ATH→SKG flight	€55	€75	€120
Rental car + fuel + tolls (÷2)	€120	€150	€200
Activities (Acropolis, museum, boat)	€90	€130	€180
City transport / taxis	€60	€90	€140
Total (land only)	~€1,075	~€1,525	~€2,340

Add international airfare to/from your home city (highly origin-dependent).

Practical pack

- **Heat:** Athens hits 35 °C+ in July. Sights early/late, siesta midday, refill water. The north is a touch milder; sea breeze on the coast.
- **Money:** Cards everywhere, but carry cash for beach bars, tavernas, tolls, and the **Diaporos boat rental**.
- **Tipping:** Round up / ~5–10% for good service; not obligatory.
- **Driving:** Motorways are tolled (cash/card). Sithonia's coast roads are windy but easy. You **don't** need a car in Athens or central Thessaloniki — only for Sithonia (Jul 6–10).
- **Connectivity:** Grab a Greece **eSIM** before flying (Airalo/Holafly) — instant data on landing.
- **A few words:** Yia sas (hello), Efharistó (thank you), Parakaló (please/you're welcome), Ya mas! (cheers).
- **Reservations:** Thessaloniki's better tables fill on summer weekends — book ~a week ahead.

Alternative: the classic Ionian island

If you'd rather have a true island (Kefalonia's Myrtos, Corfu's Old Town) and accept a transit day, **reverse the order** so the island sits next to Athens:

Athens (Jul 2–4) → **fly to the island Jul 4–8** → fly to **Thessaloniki Jul 8–10** → home.

- **Kefalonia** — Myrtos Beach, Melissani Cave, Assos, Fiskardo. Dramatic, quieter.
- **Corfu** — Venetian Old Town (UNESCO), Paleokastritsa, lush and green. Easiest island airport.
- **Catch:** no direct SKG flight either way — expect a connection (usually via Athens) on Jul 8. That single transit day is exactly why Sithonia wins for your stated route.

Sources: hotels & restaurants via Santorini Dave, Travel.gr, This Is Athens, Tripadvisor & Booking; Sithonia beaches & logistics via Thessaloniki Local, The Wom Travel, xInstransfer; flight connections via FlightConnections. Verify prices and schedules at booking time.